

The Civil Rights Movement

Weigh what changed, what changed slowly, and what stayed the same across the Civil Rights Movement (1954–1968), and judge whether it was a true turning point.

? Historical challenge

Between 1954 and 1968, courts, laws, and mass movements dismantled the legal framework of segregation. But law on paper and life on the ground are not the same thing. Compare before, during, and after — then judge: was this era a genuine turning point in U.S. history, or the acceleration of a longer struggle?

1 Investigate

SOURCES 1

Civil Rights Act (1964) – National Archives

PRIMARY SOURCE

The 1964 law banning discrimination and outlawing segregation in public accommodations and employment.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What did the Civil Rights Act make illegal?
- What might a law like this not be able to change by itself?

SOURCES 2

Voting Rights Act (1965) – National Archives

PRIMARY SOURCE

The 1965 law outlawing literacy tests and authorizing federal oversight of voter registration.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- How did this law try to protect the right to vote?
- Why might voting rights need federal enforcement?

SOURCES 3

Little Rock Central High School National Historic Site – National Park Service

SECONDARY SOURCE

How nine Black students integrated a school in 1957 and why federal troops were sent.

[Open source ↗](#)

Investigate:

- What did it take to enforce the court's desegregation order?
- What does this show about the gap between law and practice?

2 Build your Event Map

Fill in the organizer from the evidence. Mark information with ①②③ to show which source it came from. Leave a space blank if the sources don't tell you.

THE EVENT The Civil Rights Movement 1954–1968 The United States		
Before	During	After
Changed significantly	Changed gradually	Stayed mostly the same
Was this event truly a turning point? Use evidence from at least two sources.		

Sources 1

Sources 2

Sources 3

3 Compare

- Compare your ledgers with a partner. Did you sort the same items into 'changed' vs. 'stayed the same'?
- Where did you disagree about whether something changed a lot, a little, or not at all?

4 Expand

Your teacher will add context, vocabulary, and information the sources leave out. Add it to your map.

5 Revise

Go back to your Event Map. Add, correct, or reorganize based on the discussion.

6 Conclude

Was 1954–1968 a genuine turning point, or the acceleration of a longer struggle? Use evidence from at least two sources, cite specific laws or events, and address at least one way change was incomplete.